

The History of Dravidian Pronouns and Reflexives

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Abstract

The following piece gives an account of the history of the personal pronouns and reflexives in Dravidian. Personal pronouns in Dravidian are derived from a diectic root. Pronouns and reflexives in Dravidian are intriguing because they are classic cases exemplifying the blurred line [as noted in (Reinhart & Reuland, 1993)] between what we understand to be pronouns and reflexives. Derivatives of **tam* in modern Dravidian languages are both pronominal (second person honorific and non honorific) as well as reflexive. Primarily two works are referred to in this squib: the first is Robert Caldwell's *A comparative grammar of the Dravidian or South-Indian family of language* (1856) and Bhadriraju Krishnamurty's *The Dravidian languages* (2003).

1 Introduction

Pronouns and reflexives are linguistic items (free morphemes, suffixes or infixes) that lack an independent referent. They depend on a referential

noun phrase in their vicinity (clause-mate or in a neighbouring clause) or in the discourse/physical space (and are then called deictic pronouns) to be their antecedent or referent. Pronouns (like many other functional items) are linguistic items that are some of the most resistant to change, and therefore good candidates in comparative studies in the history of languages ¹

2 Dravidian Pronouns

Krishnamurti (2003) says that the Dravidian demonstrative pronouns are etymologically derived from deictic roots meaning 'this' and 'that'. Dravidian personal pronouns too have an association with these deictic roots. Caldwell (1856) however has a slightly different claim. He says that Dravidian personal pronouns are derived from the demonstratives by suffixing gender onto them. In Malayalam, for example, the distal personal pronouns, are *a-(v)-an*, *a-(v)-al* and *a-(v)-ar* while the proximal ones are *i-(v)-an*, *i-(v)-al* and *i-(v)-ar* ('he', 'she' and 'they' respectively). The distal demonstrative pronoun is *a* while the proximal one is *i*. Interestingly, the suffix *-an*, which when attached to *a-* and *i-* produces the third person singular masculine pronoun, is also found in compounds with an adjectival modifier that refer to males. It is also found in other words that refer to males, like for example, *pal-kar-an* ('milkman'), *sahodharan* ('brother'), *paiyan* ('guy'), *cherkan* ('boy'). The distribution of the suffix marking the feminine gender, *-al*, parallels that of *-an*.

Krishnamurti (2003) claims the Dravidian first person pronouns are de-

¹In Dravidian languages, while most nouns are derived from verbs, the pronouns are underived.

Dravidian	Australian	Tibetan	Chinese
nan, na, en	nga ngaii, ngatsa, nganya	nga, nge, nged	ngo

Table 1: First Person Singular Pronouns in Dravidian, Australian, Tibetan and Chinese

rived from two sources that are not etymologically related. Some are derived from the Proto-Dravidian **yan/yan-* and some, found only in South Dravidian I and South Dravidian II, are derived from Proto-South Dravidian **ñan/*ñan-*. Proto-Dravidian had two kinds of plurals, one including the addressee (the inclusive plural) and one excluding them (the exclusive plural). This is retained in modern Dravidian, where there are exclusive and inclusive first person plural pronouns, like Malayalam *naṇaḷ* (exclusive) and *naṁmaḷ* (inclusive)

2.1 Dravidian pronouns and pronouns in Australian aboriginal languages

Caldwell (1856) is believed to be first descriptive accounts of the Dravidian languages with focus on their family-hood. About pronouns in this family, he claims that there is an unquestionable resemblance between Dravidian first person singular pronouns and those in Aboriginal languages of southern and western Australia. He also notes a similarity with Sino-Tibetan languages. His comparison is reproduced in Table 1.

He goes on to note that the way the first person singular is pluralised in Telugu, resembles the way it is dualised and pluralised in Australian dialects. In Telugu, the plural is formed by suffixing *-lu* (*vad-u* 'he' pluralised to *vad-lu* 'they'), and in the Austrian dialects by suffixing *-lu*, *-li*, *-dlu*, *-dli*

	Dravidian	Australian
thou	nin, nin	ninna nginne, ngintoa, ningte
you	nim, nim, nir, num, niwu	nimedoo, nura, niwa, ngurle

Table 2: First Person Singular Pronouns in Dravidian, Australian, Tibetan and Chinese

(*ngalu* 'we').²

However, the similarity between the Dravidian and Australian second person pronouns and their plurals is even more striking. This is evident from Table 2.

The accusative form of the first person singular in Tamil *ennei* 'me', resembles the Australian accusative *emmo*. Interestingly, the oblique in Tamil (from which the accusative is derived) is claimed to be derived from proto Dravidian, as opposed to Proto-South Dravidian. Malayalam, Telugu, Kannada, Tulu too have *en-* as the oblique form of the first person singular (Krishnamurti, 2003).

3 Dravidian Reflexives

The morphological form of the reflexive is quite consistent throughout the Dravidian languages, with even the Brahui reflexive (*ten*) being related to the Proto Dravidian one. Caldwell proposes that **ta* is the root of the reflexive in Dravidian languages, Krishnamurti says it can be traced back to Proto-Dravidian **tam*. the *-n*³ in *tan* (the singular reflexive in most Dravid-

²He also notes a similarity between Dhimal (Sino-Tibetan) second person pronouns *na* 'thou' and *nyel* 'you', and Dravidian second person pronouns like Tamil and Malayalam *ni* and Kannada *ninu*.

³note that Caldwell clarifies that *-n* in *tan* is unrelated to the *-n* in *avan/ivan*, because the former does not mark gender

ian languages), Caldwell says is a "formative addition" (like the final 'n' in *nan* ('I')). It is present even in Brahui, forcing him to conclude that it is of great antiquity.

tan can also be used as a focus marker (or emphatic marker) by adding it to each personal and demonstrative pronoun [as shown in (1) and (2) below from Malayalam]

(1) *avan-tanne* (intended: 'he himself')

(2) *ithu/athu-tanne* (intended: 'this/that itself')

In Tamil, *tan* even acquires an adverbial signification when an adverbial formative is added, as in (3), and when it is appended to nouns of quality or relation [as in (4)]

(3) *tanagi* 'of yourself'

(4) *seri tan* 'quite right'

Interestingly, the reflexive is also used as a honorific substitute for the second person pronoun. Depending upon the level of politeness and intimacy, either the singular or the plural is used. For example, in Malayalam, it is the plural form of the reflexive that marks honorificity. The singular is used as a second person pronoun in non-honorific contexts (for instance, to address friends). That the singular is considered impolite, is even more evident because women are never addressed by men using the singular reflexive.

Caldwell even proposes that Hindi-Urdu *tu* might be related to *tan*, both originating from a demonstrative base⁴. Further, an entire class of words

⁴the demonstrative in Dravidian is *ta*

in Tamil, denoting parents, near relations are said to have originated from the honorific use of the reflexive. These include the words *tagappan* 'father' (from *tam-appan* 'his paternity'), *tammei* 'mother' (from *tam-ayi* 'her maternity'), *tamayan* 'elder brother', *tang-gei* 'younger sister', *tambi* 'younger brother' and *tambiran* (a title for God). The word for quality or nature (lit. selfness) is *tan-mei* or *tanam* and is claimed to have originated from reflexive pronoun. This word is identical in meaning with Sanskrit *tatvam* 'nature/property' nature, property, which is derived from *tad* or *tat*. Their bases could be possibly allied in origin.

Caldwell, studying the meaning and range of the reflexive and the words he believes are derived from it (or its base *ta*), suggest that the reflexive must have originated from a demonstrative base. Demonstratives resembling *ta*, he says, are found in Indo-Aryan as well as Greek. This includes Sanskrit *ta-d* 'that' (where *ta* is the demonstrative and *-d* the sign of the neuter singular), *tada* 'then/at that time' and *sah* 'he' (with 't' changing to 's'). The claim is that the Sanskrit reflexive *sva-* and *tan* have the same base (the Sanskrit one having undergone considerable change). The demonstrative pronoun to from Old Greek, the Finnish remote demonstrative *tuo* and the proximate *tama*, Ostiak remote demonstrative *toma* and proximate *tema*, Lappish *tat* 'he' and Old Prussian *tanas* 'he' are also said to be related to the Dravidian reflexive.

To tie things together, in Gondi, the reflexive pronoun is also used as a demonstrative. However, the most compelling argument for considering Dravidian *ta/tam* to be allied to Scytho-Sanskrit demonstrative *ta* is the fact that the word *tanmei* or *tanam* (quality or selfness) in Dravidian is seman-

tically parallel to Sanskrit *tatvam* (quality or thatness).

4 Note 1

The two stories sketched above, the first, the similarity between Dravidian pronouns and pronouns in Australian languages, as discussed in Section 2.1 and the second, the link that the Dravidian reflexive seems to have with Indo-European when put together with the story of migration of the human race out of the African continent, indicate towards a hypothesis that must be tested. If the ancestors of the Australian languages were separated from the ancestors of the Indian languages, when a group migrated from Africa towards the Indian Sub-Continent and towards Australia, before the Indo-Aryan languages set root in the Indian subcontinent, then we would expect the reflexives in the Australian languages to be distinct from that in the Dravidian languages, unlike the case with the personal pronouns. This is something that is absolutely speculative and warrants further research for credibility. However, one thing is clear, the history of Dravidian pronouns and reflexives is a gateway to the histories of the various language families that have interacted with it.

4.1 Note 2: Pronouns and gender

‘he’ and ‘it’ are the only third person singular pronouns that Caldwell notes are used in Telugu (and Gondi). There is no pronoun dedicated to refer-

ring to females. Women are referred to as 'things', ⁵ However, in modern Telugu, girls and inanimates are referred to using the same pronouns *idi* (3SG.proximal) and *adi* (3SG.distal), while there is indeed a separate pronoun to refer to women (*eeme*). On the other hand, there are distinct pronouns to refer to boys (*veedu*, *eeyana* or *eena*). In Malayalam, Kannada and Tamil, this is not the case; there are special pronouns dedicated to refer to girls and women in the singular, for instance, in Malayalam, the pronouns are *ival* (proximal) and *aval* (distal). In Telugu, women taken collectively, however, are referred to with the same suffixes and pronouns that are applied to men and gods, like in Malayalam, Kannada and Tamil [take for example, Malayalam *avar* (3PL). In Toda and Kota, there no pronouns for the feminine singular. However, instead of using the neuter (as happens in Telugu), these use the masculine pronoun to refer to women [as in Old Hebrew and Bangla, where the same pronoun, *hu* and *o* respectively, are used to refer to both males and females]

References

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- Reinhart, T., & Reuland, E. (1993). Reflexivity. *Linguistic Inquiry*.

⁵According to Caldwell 'in the supposition either that women are destitute of reason, or that their reason, like that of infants, lies dormant.'